

LOW ACID FOODS



Teens (14–18)

Q

Why do low acid foods need to be canned in a pressure canner instead of a boiling water canner?

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ANSWER

Because their low acidity allows harmful bacteria, like *Clostridium botulinum*, to survive unless processed at higher temperatures.

FUN FACT

Pressure canners reach temperatures above 240°F to kill dangerous bacteria in low acid foods.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Q

What is the typical pressure setting for processing low acid foods in a weighted gauge pressure canner at sea level?

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ANSWER

10 pounds of pressure

FUN FACT

Even a few pounds difference in pressure can affect how well your food is preserved safely.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Q

When using a dial gauge pressure canner, what pressure is generally recommended at sea level for low acid foods?

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ANSWER

11 pounds of pressure

FUN FACT

Dial gauges need to be tested yearly for accuracy to keep your food safe!

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Q

How should you adjust pressure processing times or pressure when canning at high altitudes?

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ANSWER

Increase pressure or processing time according to altitude adjustment charts

FUN FACT

At higher altitudes, water boils at lower temperatures, so you need to adjust to kill bacteria effectively.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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What is a crucial step before putting the weighted gauge on a pressure canner vent pipe?

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ANSWER

Vent a steady stream of steam for 10 minutes to purge air

FUN FACT

Purging air allows the canner to reach the correct temperature for safe processing.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Why must jars be placed on a rack inside a pressure canner instead of directly on the bottom?

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ANSWER

To allow steam circulation and prevent jar breakage

FUN FACT

Good steam circulation ensures even heat and safe preservation.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans



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What is the consequence of opening a pressure canner lid immediately after processing is finished?

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ANSWER

**Risk of severe steam burns
from sudden steam release**

FUN FACT

*Always wait 5-10 minutes after
pressure drops to zero before opening
the lid.*

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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What does the dial gauge on a pressure canner measure?

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ANSWER

The pressure inside the canner in pounds per square inch (psi)

FUN FACT

Correct pressure ensures low acid foods reach the temperature needed to destroy bacteria.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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How long should pint jars of low acid foods be processed in a pressure canner at 10-11 pounds pressure?

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ANSWER

**About 65 to 75 minutes
depending on the food**

FUN FACT

*Processing time varies by food, so
always follow tested recipes carefully.*

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Q

What happens if low acid foods are canned using a boiling water canner instead of a pressure canner?

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ANSWER

Dangerous bacteria may survive and cause spoilage or illness

FUN FACT

Pressure canning is necessary because boiling water reaches only 212°F, but 240°F+ is needed for safety.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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What is the role of altitude in pressure canning low acid foods?

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ANSWER

Higher altitude means lower boiling temperature, so pressure or time must be increased

FUN FACT

Knowing your altitude helps you adjust safely when home canning.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans



Q

What tool can be used to check the accuracy of a dial gauge on a pressure canner?

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ANSWER

Have it tested at your local Extension office or a canning center

FUN FACT

Annual testing of dial gauges ensures your food safety during canning.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Which types of foods are considered low acid and require pressure canning?

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ANSWER

Vegetables, meats, poultry, fish, and most beans

FUN FACT

Low acid foods have a pH above 4.6, making them risky if not processed correctly.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans



Q

What is a weighted gauge on a pressure canner?

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ANSWER

A device that maintains pressure by releasing excess steam at a set pressure level

FUN FACT

Weighted gauges are simple and reliable for maintaining correct pressure.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans



Q

What is the headspace you should leave in jars when pressure canning low acid foods?

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ANSWER

About 1 inch to allow for food expansion

FUN FACT

Correct headspace helps prevent jars from breaking and ensures seals form properly.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Q

How long should you vent steam before placing the pressure weight or closing the petcock when starting to process low acid foods?

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ANSWER

10 minutes to remove air and allow steam to fill the canner

FUN FACT

Removing air is essential so the canner reaches the right temperature and pressure.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Why is it unsafe to open the pressure canner lid before the pressure returns to zero?

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ANSWER

Because the sudden release of pressure and steam can cause serious injuries

FUN FACT

Safety first! Always wait for pressure to drop naturally before opening.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans

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Which is true about processing times when canning different sized jars together?

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ANSWER

All jars must be processed for the time required by the largest jar size

FUN FACT

Better safe than sorry: longer times ensure all jars are fully processed.

Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home

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What should you do if the rubber seal on your pressure canner lid is cracked or damaged?

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ANSWER

Replace it before pressure canning to ensure a proper seal and safety

FUN FACT

A good seal keeps the high pressure and temperatures inside the canner.

Source: PNW 421 Use care operation of your pressure canner

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How much water should you add to a pressure canner when canning low acid foods?

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ANSWER

Usually 2 inches of simmering water to produce steam for processing

FUN FACT

Water creates the steam needed to raise the temperature above boiling.

Source: EM 9435 Preserving dried beans